

MASTER Minds

NIIT'S chess academy aims at spreading the gospel of chess in every corner of the country

It's called the Scholar's Mate, four moves from opening to checkmate, learnt almost greedily by the most enthusiastic beginners taking to the chess board. "It's amazing how many try it on me," world champion and world No. 1 Viswanathan Anand says, a wide grin breaking on his face. Every year, his simultaneous duels with young chess players forms part of the grand finale to the series of the NIIT Mind Champions Academy (MCA).

Anand is central to the MCA, not merely as its face, mascot or brand ambassador. He is the messenger for the gospel of chess itself. The MCA is the most comprehensive chess programme being run in the country. It works through a year-long calendar of competitions that run from inter-school to districts and districts to zones

ISHAN TANNOKA



BEGINNING BIG: Anand takes on the MCA tykes all the way up to the national level and ends with the best school players getting a chance to take on Anand—and try the Scholar's Mate, if they so choose.

The current edition will go to 4,000 government and private schools and involve more than 1,75,000 students between the ages of 6 and 17. The students receive on-line and offline training to improve their chess skills though Anand clarifies, "This is not a coaching programme—it's a way to get more and more kids playing chess, to build a critical mass of players, to get schools enthusiastic about chess because of its knock-on benefits on academics." Last year's champions came from a school called Sunbeam in Varanasi.

The 2008-09 MCA series was launched in May when Anand conducted a live tutorial across 12 cities for 300 children. The programme though has taken him—and the gospel of the chequered board—to smaller metros like Raipur, Guwahati and Agartala.



everyone was relieved only to have made it." Popat understands that the private funds have directly impacted the athletes "in the kind of fitness training and physio back-up you can get". It may seem a routine benefit, but it is the difference between hope and anonymity. Ask Mohammed Ali Qamar, Commonwealth Games boxing gold medallist in 2002, who now competes only in national and inter-railway meets, tossed aside by his sport as an injured and burnt-out case.

Akhil Kumar, a Commonwealth Games gold medallist four years after Qamar, could have gone the same way. Repeated punching caused such severe bruising in his wrist bones that he was advised to give up boxing as the injury could not be treated. "Toot gaya tha main (I was a broken man)," he says, but got a second chance and a life-line because by then, he was on the MCT roster. A round of doctors' appointments, a minor surgery in South Africa and 10 months of rehabilitation later he had a single shot at Olympic qualifying and earned his ticket to Beijing. He is now the senior-most fighter in the largest Indian boxing team at Olympics, where medal rounds have evaded all their predecessors like slippery opponents. "This is just a barrier," says Kumar, "If it breaks once—boxing will get a medal at every Olympics." If he happens to be the one to smash the barrier, he says, he will give his medal over to the MCT. "They have looked after me like parents."

This sudden rollout of a carpet of possibilities for the athletes, administrators believe, is not enough. "It's a fantastic first step," says former Olympic sprinter Adille Sumariwala,